dhi) was particularly disliked by those who wanted Hindus to take revenge or who wanted India to become a country for the Hindus, just as Pakistan was for the Muslims. They accused Gandhiji of acting in the interests of the Muslims and Pakistan. Gandhiji thought that these people were misguided. He was convinced that any attempt to make India into a country only for the Hindus would destroy India. His steadfast pursuit of Hindu-Muslim unity provoked Hindu extremists so much that they made several attempts to assassinate Gandhiji."

Another deleted portion reads: "Gandhiji's death had an almost magical effect on the communal situation in the country. Partition-related anger and violence suddenly subsided. The Government of India cracked down on organisations that were spreading communal hatred. Organisations like the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh were banned for some time. Communal politics began to lose its appeal." In the history textbook for Class 12, titled *Themes of Indian History-Part III*, references to Godse and his assassination of Gandhi were altered. Earlier it read: "Gandhiji was shot dead by a young man. The assassin, who surrendered afterwards, was a Brahmin from Pune named Nathuram Godse, the editor of an extremist Hindu newspaper who had denounced Gandhiji as an appeaser of Muslims." Now it reads: "At his daily prayer meeting on the evening of 30 January, Gandhiji was shot dead by a young man. The assassin, who surrendered afterwards, was Nathuram Godse."

While NCERT director Professor Dinesh Prasad Saklani attributes the absence of the "new deletions" in the June list to a possible "oversight", academicians and opposition political leaders denounce it as a blatant attempt by the BJP government to delete inconvenient truths related to the past of the party and its ideological fountainhead, the RSS. "Replacing history with a version more suitable to its ideology has been the agenda of the Sangh Parivar," says Tushar Gandhi, author and great-grandson of Mahatma Gandhi. "It's not at all surprising that NCERT has specifically deleted references where the Sangh could be implicated in Bapu's murder."



"THE EXPERT COMMITTEE SUGGESTED DELETIONS BASED ON WHAT WAS NOT NECESSARY OR REPEATED IN OTHER CLASSES OR BOOKS"

–PROF. D.P. SAKLANI
Director, NCERT

INCONVENIENT TRUTHS?

The most controversial omission last year was in the last chapter of the Class 12 political science textbook—two whole pages on the 2002 Gujarat riots were deleted. The first page mentioned the National Human Rights Commission's criticism of the Gujarat government for failing to control the violence. The second page had former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's famous "raj dharma" remark. "My one message to the Chief Minister (of Gujarat) is that he should follow 'raj dharma'. A ruler should not make any discrimination between his subjects on the basis of caste, creed and religion," Vajpayee had said at a press conference in Ahmedabad in March 2002, with Narendra Modi, the then chief minister of Gujarat, sitting by his side. In the government's defence, Prof. Makkhan Lal points out, "Hindu Muslim riots were mentioned selectively. Why not talk about the Ahmedabad riots of 1967-70 and 1985, which killed thousands of people and often lasted for six months or more?" (See accompanying column: *Setting the Record Straight.*)

Critics also accuse the ruling party of vilifying Muslim rulers, particularly the Mughals, and thus depriving students knowledge of a crucial period in subcontinental history. Content related to the Mughals and Muslims has faced cuts across classes. In the Class 12 history textbook, *Themes of Indian History-Part II*, the chapter, 'Kings and Chronicles': the 'Mughal Courts' (C. 16th and 17th centuries) (Theme 9) has been dropped. The chapter included references to Mughal-era manuscripts like the *Akbarnama* and the *Padshahnama* and the court protocols of Mughal rulers. In the Class 7 history textbook, *Our Pasts-II*, a two-page chart in the chapter detailing the achievements of Mughal emperors such as Humayun, Shah Jahan, Akbar, Jahangir and Aurangzeb has been removed from the chapter 'The Mughal Empire'. A section on 'Akbar's policies', including the broad features of his administration, his interest in the religious and social customs of different people and how he commissioned the translation of Sanskrit works into Persian has also disappeared.

Also "rationalised" is a chapter on the 'rise of popular movements' in the Class 12 political science textbook. These included the Chipko movement in what is modern-day Uttarakhand, the Dalit Panthers in Maharashtra, the anti-liquor movement of Andhra Pradesh, the agrarian struggles of the 1980s and the Narmada Bachao Andolan (NBA). What has survived is the movement leading to the Right to Information Act but in a separate box. In the sociology textbook, *Social Change and Development in India*, for the same class, an exercise box asking students to discuss the recent farmers' protests against farm laws has gone.